

Will McGowan

9 Clarendon Place, Glasgow G20 7PZ

+44 7562 299 515 | mcgowanwill366@gmail.com

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Graduate Recruitment Team

Mako

London

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am applying for the Graduate Trader Programme in London. I am a final-year Economics student at the University of Strathclyde, graduating in summer 2027 with a predicted 2:1. Mako's options market making across fixed income, equity and commodity derivatives, which it has run since 1999, is the business I want to learn from the ground up.

Most of what I am proudest of comes down to good decisions made with incomplete information. Playing 12 poker tables at once, I based every decision on expected value and set my stakes with the Kelly criterion, keeping at least 50 buy-ins because an edge estimated from my own results could be overstated. I also finished 14th at the Irish U19 Chess Championships in 2023 and won 21 of 22 games in a simultaneous exhibition against players with an average FIDE rating of 1860. As Vice-President and then President of the Strathclyde Poker Society, I ran weekly tournaments for around 60 players on a £600 budget per semester and taught new members to use the same method to work out how many buy-ins their own win rate, variance and risk tolerance call for.

I pair that instinct with quantitative work I can defend line by line. I built a Monte Carlo option pricer in which a geometric-Asian control variate cut the standard error of arithmetic-Asian estimates by 97% at 100,000 paths, and my dissertation tests whether sovereign oil hedges make petro-currencies' oil betas smaller, kinked or one-sided on OPEC announcement days, with a pre-registered test of whether what remains is tradable. Proprietary trading appeals to me because the feedback is immediate and impartial: every decision is priced, and improving means learning faster than the market. Nearly two years of busy bar shifts alongside full-time study, and now running the drinks programme as Head Mixologist at a new 200-cover Glasgow venue, have taught me to stay accurate when speed matters.

Mako stands out to me because its eighteen-month graduate programme builds option theory, risk processes and live market-making experience step by step, at a firm small enough that a graduate's progress is visible. My Monte Carlo engine taught me how option values respond to volatility and to the path a price takes, and I would like to turn that understanding into quoting real markets within Mako's risk framework.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Will McGowan